The Screaming Woman

By Ray Bradbury

My name is Margaret Leary and I'm ten years old. I've got a nice father and mother, except they don't pay much attention to me. Anyway, we never thought we'd have anything to do with a murdered woman. Or almost.

When you're just living on a street like we live on, you don't think awful things are going to happen, like shooting or stabbing or burying people under the ground, practically in your back yard. And when it does happen you don't believe it. You just go on buttering your toast or baking a cake.

INTRODUCTION

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It was noon in the middle of July. I was just walking along, across the empty lot behind our house, when all of a sudden it happened.

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I heard the Screaming Woman.

I stopped and listened.

It was coming up out of the ground.

A woman was buried under the rocks and dirt and glass, and she was screaming, all wild and horrible, for someone to dig her out.

Then I started to run. I fell down, got up, and ran some more. I got in the screen door of my house and there was mama.

"Mama . . . There's a Screaming Woman in the empty lot. . . We got to dig her out. She's buried under tons and tons of dirt and if we don't dig her out she'll choke up and die."

"I'm certain she can wait until after lunch," said Mama.

"Mama, don't you believe me?"

"Of course dear, now wash your hands and take this plate of meat in to your father."

I went into the dining room "Hi, Dad, there's a Screaming Woman in the empty lot . . . We've got to get

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picks and shovels and excavate, like for an Egyptian mummy"

"I don't feel like an archeologist, Margaret." Said Father. "No, some nice cool October day, I'll take you up on that."

"But we can't wait that long," I almost screamed. My heart was bursting and here was Dad, putting meat on his plate, cutting and chewing and paying me no attention.

"Dad, you just gotta help. I'll give you all the money in my piggy bank!"

"Margaret, tell you what . . . after lunch, I'll come out and listen to your Screaming Woman, free of charge, But you must eat.

Lunch was a million years long. Everybody moved in slow motion, like those films you see at the movies. It was so slow. I wanted to scream, "Hurry! Oh, please!"

But no, I had to sit, and all the while we sat there slowly, slowly eating our lunch, out there in the empty lot (I could hear her screaming in my mind. Scream!) was the Screaming Woman all alone.

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"There we are," said Dad, finished at last.

"*Now* will you come out to see the Screaming Woman?" I said

"Speaking of the Screaming Woman," said Mother, "Charlie Nesbitt and his wife Helen had another fight last night"

"That's nothing new," said Father. "They're always fighting.

"If you ask me, Charlie's no good," said Mother. "Or her either."

"Oh, I don't know," said Dad. "I think she's pretty nice."

"You're prejudiced. After all, you almost married her."

"Dad," I said

"Charlie has got a terrible temper" said Dad."Remember when Helen had the lead in our high-school play? She wrote some songs for it herself. That was the summer she wrote that song for me. Let's see, how did it go?" (HUMMING)

"Dad," I said.

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"You'd better take your daughter out in the back lot before she collapses." said Mother, "You can sing me that wonderful song later."

The empty lot was still empty and hot and the glass sparkled green and white and brown all around where the bottles lay.

"Now, where's this Screaming Woman?" laughed Dad.

"Listen," I said. We listened. "Shhh . . . Wait." We heard the wind in the trees. That was all.

"Margaret, " said Father. " I suggest you go lie down and put a damp cloth on your forehead."

"But she was here," I shouted. "I heard her, screaming and screaming and screaming. See, here's where the ground's been dug up. I called frantically at the earth. "Hey there, you down there!"

"Margaret," said Father. This is the place where Mr. Kelly dug yesterday, a big hole, to bury his garbage."

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"But during the night," I said, "someone else used Mr. Kelly's burying place to bury a woman. And covered it all over again."

"Better not stay out here too long," said Dad. "It's hot." Dad walked off.

I stamped on the ground. "Darn." I said. The screaming started again.

I ran to the garage, got a couple of shovels and ran to the empty lot. I started to dig, and all the while I dug, the Screaming Woman screamed. . . .

It was hard work. I knew I'd be doing it all afternoon and maybe I wouldn't finish in time. What could I do? Run tell other people. But they'd be like Mom and Dad, pay no attention. I just kept digging, all by myself.

About ten minutes later, Dippy Smith came along the path through the empty lot. He goes to my school.

"Hi, Margaret what are you doing?"

"Digging for the Screaming Lady."

"I don't hear no screaming."

"You wait a while and you will. Still help me dig"

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"I don't dig unless I hear a scream"

We waited. A scream came out of the ground.

"Hot dog! Give me a shovel."

We kept digging, and then a shadow fell across us.

"Hey, you kids, what you think you're doing? It was Mr. Kelly, the man who owned the empty lot. "Shovel that soil right back into that hole!"

My heart started beating fast again.

"But Mr. Kelly, there's a Screaming Woman-"

"I'm not interested. . . . Go on now, fill it up and get home before I give you my foot!"

I turned to Dippy, "He's the one, and he buried Mrs. Kelly here. There's only one thing to do . . . call the police."

We ran for the corner store telephone.

The police knocked on Mr. Kelly's door five minutes later. Dippy and I hid in the bushes, listening.

"Mr. Kelly?"

"Yes, sir, what can I do for you?"

"Is Mrs. Kelly at home?"

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"Yes Sir, Hey Anna!"

Mrs. Kelly came to the door.

"I beg your pardon, but we had a report that you were buried out in an empty lot, Mrs. Kelly"

We both ran.

"What'll we do now?"

"We don't dare go near that empty lot again."

"So long," said Dippy. I was left all alone, no one to help me. There was only one last thing to do. I went from house to house, all down the street. I rang every bell and when the door opened, I said, "Hello, Mrs. So-and-So, you're looking fine today." And once I saw that the lady of the house was home, I went on down the street.

I was about to give up when I knocked on the door of Charlie Nesbitt. Instead of Mrs. Nesbitt, or Helen as my father caller her, coming to the door, why it was Mr. Nesbitt, Charlie, himself.

"Oh," he said. "it's you, Margaret. What can I do for you?"

"I'd like to see your wife"

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"Well, she's gone out to the store," he said.

"I'll wait," I said, and slipped in past him. I sat down in a chair. "My, it's a hot day," I said, trying to be calm, thinking about the empty lot and air going out of the box and the screams getting weaker and weaker.

"Listen, kid," said Charlie, coming over to me, "My wife won't be back. Not today, that is. She's gone to the store, like I said, but, but, she's going on from there to visit her mother. Yeah. She's going to visit her mother, in Schenectady. She'll be back, two or three days, maybe a week."

"That's a shame," I said. "I wanted to tell her there's a woman buried over in the empty lot, screaming under tons and tons of dirt."

Mr. Nesbitt dropped his cigarette. . . "Well, I'll tell Helen when she comes home, your story.

"Thanks. It's a real woman."

"How do you know it is?"

"I heard her."

He tried to be casual. "Say kid, you, eh, you *say* anything about this to anyone?"

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"Sure, I told lots of people."

"Anybody doing anything about it?"

"No, " I said. "They won't believe me."

"He smiled. "Of course. Naturally. You're nothing but a kid. Why should they listen to you?"

"I'm going back now and dig her out with a spade," I said. "I got to go."

"Plenty of time for that," he said, quite. "Let's play a game of black jack, it's more fun than Screaming Women."

I knew what he was trying to do. He was trying to keep me in his house until the screaming died down and was gone. He was trying to keep me from helping her. I knew what his plan was. He'd sneak down in the middle of the night and dig up his wife, and take her somewhere else and bury her, good. He finally let me go because he thought that by now the air must all be gone from the box.

I went back to the empty lot and hid in some bushes. What could I do? Tell my folks? But they hadn't believe me. Call the police on Charlie Nesbitt?

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But he said his wife as away visiting. Nobody would believe me!

The screaming had stopped. It was so quiet I thought I would never hear a scream again. I bent down and put my ear against the ground.

And then I heard it, way down, way deep, and so faint I could hardly hear it.

The woman wasn't screaming any more. . She was singing. Something about, "I loved you fair, I loved you well." It was sort of a sad son. Very faint. And sort of broken.

I walked to my house and opened the front door.

"Father, she's not screaming anymore. She's singing now. And she'll be dead soon if you don't listen to me. She's out there there, singing: "I loved you fair, I loved you well. . . "

Dad's face grew pale. "Where did you *hear* that song?" he shouted.

"Out in the empty lot, just now"

"But that's *Helen's* song, the one she wrote, years ago, for me! You can't know it. *Nobody knew it,*

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except Helen and me. I never sang it to anyone. Oh, my God!" cried Father, and ran out the door.

The last I saw of him he was in the empty lot, digging, and lots of other people with him, digging.

I felt so happy. I wanted to cry.

I dialed a number on the phone and when Dippy answered I said, "Hi Dippy. Everything's fine. Everything's worked out. The Screaming Woman isn't screaming anymore"

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